hostility and suspicion; which over-emphasised the supreme threat of Russia to Britain's imperial interests in South Asia; which saw Persia and Afghanistan as mere pawns; and which insisted on the use of the 'iron hand' to extend Britain's influence in the region. Crucially, the Great Game mentality therefore blinded Curzon to the growth of nationalism and pan-Islamism in South Asia in the years after the First World War.[2] And it is this which brought the foreign secretary into conflict with the Indian government. Curzon saw the world as he thought it ought to be – and perhaps as it was prior to 1914. He did not see it as it was. The foreign secretary's inability to recognise why the agreement had failed is a clear indication of just how little he understood the changes which had overcome Persia since his travelling days.

The trouble was that Curzon's obsession with Russia had had a long gestation – formulated during his early travels, and solidified while he was viceroy. It meant that it was hard for him to see anything else as a comparable threat. Which leads to another question posed in the beginning of this work – how far was the foreign secretary actually fearful of Bolshevism taking hold in South Asia? Was his anti-Bolshevik rhetoric based on ideological antipathy? Or to put it another way, was Curzon anti-Bolshevik or actually anti-Russian? And more importantly, does it actually matter? In 1918–1919, there certainly appeared to be some confusion in London over who was the real threat to Britain's interests in Persia: the remnants of the tsarist regime in the form of the Cossack Division and the Russian Legation, or the new revolutionary government in Moscow. Indeed, despite Curzon's anti-Bolshevik rhetoric, in these early years it was certainly the Cossack Division which could cause more immediate problems for Britain in Persia, given that the Bolshevik regime was distracted by the Russian civil war. A cynic could argue that Curzon realised he would have been unable to push through his Persian plans if he had couched them in imperialistic terms. In these months after the conclusion of the First World War there was great reluctance for Britain to be extending its responsibilities further than it had to. But Bolshevism provided a convenient justification – Britain needed to protect the Persians from this destructive ideology (or so Curzon claimed).